

Fury of the PATRIARCH

Bhairon Singh Shekhawat's rebellion only brings out the biggest challenge the party faces: the enemy within

| By Rohit Parihar and Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

When the last lion of Rajasthan roars, you had better take notice. The ageing king of the desert is angry, wounded, and demands attention. To his horror, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat is realising that he is fast ceasing to be the first among equals. The unbearable isolation has made the former vice-president of India angrier. And the BJP, the party that grew under his formidable shadow, is not scared, at least for the moment.

The struggle of the patriarch to get noticed continues. He insists that he would contest in the coming general elections. And he doesn't mind becoming the prime minister. Before such great things happen, he wants an inquiry into the alleged Rs 22,000-crore corruption charges against Vasundhara Raje, former chief minister of Rajasthan and now the leader of Opposition. Arrest her, send her to jail if found guilty, he says.

Raje is not his only target. In his firing line are some senior leaders cutting across party lines. Shekhawat claims he has piles of papers as evidence of corruption against some Union ministers. Also on his radar are some central leaders of his own party, particularly from the GenNext. He is

believed to be waiting for the right time to strike, and by all indications, we have not heard the last from the man.

What does Shekhawat want? At 86, he should be a contented old man: three-time chief minister of Rajasthan; the leader who made the party a force in the state; and a much-beloved veep. Then why has he become the BJP's biggest threat from within, though formally, he ceased to be a party member when he was elected vice-president of the country? Why is he hobnobbing with parties that scuttled his bid for the presidency?

Shekhawat never wanted to retire from party politics. He waited for a formal invitation from his party. If not an active role, he thought he could at least be the wise counsellor or the patron saint. But the party has only space for two titans—Lal Krishna Advani, the prime ministerial candidate, and Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who has already retired from active politics. Shekhawat knew he would not be the tallest leader, and he also knew he was tall enough to challenge the high command.

When Shekhawat talks against corruption, no one can question his credibility. Then why had he been

